CURATING HISTORY

2.1 The Henry Ford Museum Dearborn, Michigan

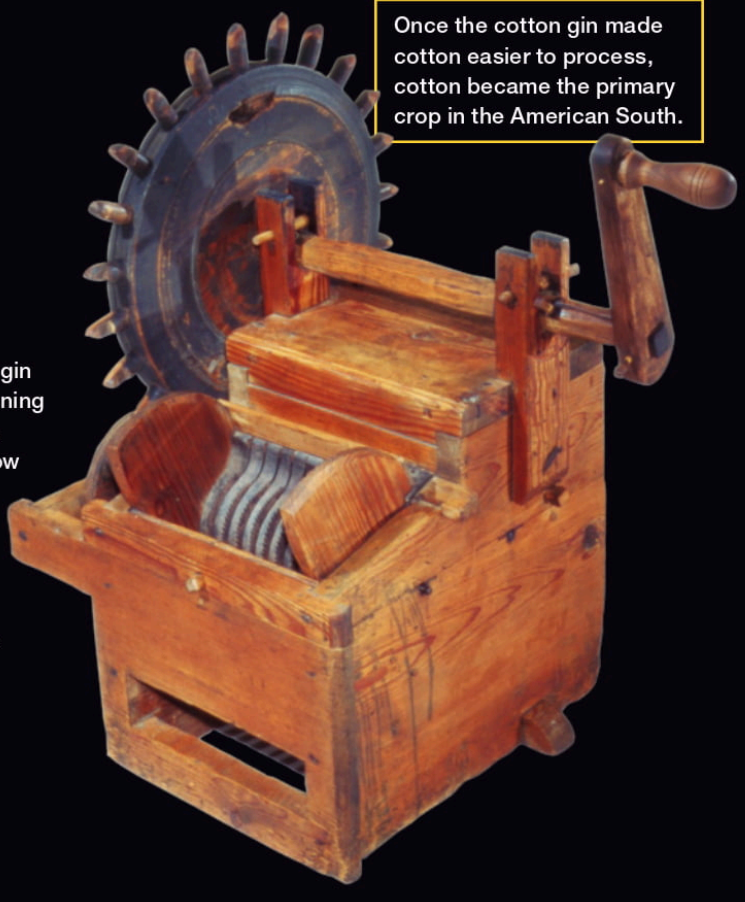
One of the world's wealthiest and most influential innovators, Henry Ford grew up on a farm and never lost his ties to rural life. He became a collector of objects from ordinary people and examples of industrial progress and opened a museum in 1929 to share them with the public. The Henry Ford Museum's mission is to provide unique educational experiences based on authentic objects, stories, and lives that represent America's ingenuity, resourcefulness, and innovation. Its impressive collection of American artifacts includes many items related to the cotton industry. How do the artifacts below reflect the cotton production process?



One bale of cotton can make 1,217 men's T-shirts or 313,600 $100 bills.

Cotton Blossom

Cotton grows on shrubs in 17 states across the southern half of the country. Cotton plants first produce blossoms, which change from white to pink and fall off after a few days. In their place grow small green pods called bolls. Cotton seeds and their attached hairs develop within the bolls, which swell and grow. When the boll is ripe, it bursts into the white, fluffy balls shown here. The seed hair has turned into the fibers used to make cloth and thread.



Once the cotton gin made cotton easier to process, cotton became the primary crop in the American South.

Cotton Gin

Invented by Eli Whitney in 1793, the cotton gin machine revolutionized the process of cleaning seeds out of cotton. Whitney was visiting a friend in the South when he heard about how farmers struggled to efficiently process their cotton crops. He quickly solved their problem with a device that pulled the cotton through a set of wire teeth mounted on a spinning cylinder. The cotton fibers could fit through narrow slots in the machine, but the seeds couldn't.



Spinning Wheel

Spinning fibers into yarn that was then woven into cloth was an important task in many households in the 1600s and 1700s. Young or unmarried women often became experts at this tedious and physically tiring task. This large spinning wheel would have required its spinner to alternate between spinning fibers into yarn and winding the yarn onto the spindle.



Fluffy raw wool or cotton fibers were spun into fine yarn used to make clothing.

"Ford's perspective on history was informed by a strong belief in **the power of learning by doing.**"

—Marc Greuther, Chief Curator, The Henry Ford Museum

Why would advertising thread have been so common during the 1800s?





Cotton Thread Trade Cards

Without cotton, there is no thread, and without thread, there is no clothing! The cotton industry remained strong throughout American history, as demonstrated by these trade cards for "spool cotton" or thread, which date to the late 1800s. Advertisers appealed to customers with colorful ads promoting consumer goods such as thread.

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